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Original Page: 239**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** 1951-1959**Coverage Date:** 1951-1959**Place Coverage**

Nyae Nyae region of Namibia and Botswana

Section Title(S): MEAT-SHARING

It ends in everybody getting some meat.

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In the later waves of sharing, when the primary distribution and primary kinship obligations have been fulfilled, the giving of meat from one's own portion has the quality of gift-giving. !Kung society requires at this point only that a person should give with reasonable generosity in proportion to what he has received and not keep more than an equitable amount for himself in the end, and that the person who receives a gift of meat must give a reciprocal gift some time in the future. Such factors as the category of relationship of kin, affines, or non-related persons, the joking relationship, status, and band affiliation impose no pattern on this giving. People give to whom they please, this time to some, next time to others, more generously or less generously according to their own (to us often unfathomable) reasons. We are certain, however, that the motives are the same as in gift-giving in general: to measure up to what is expected of them, to make friendly gestures, to win favour, to repay past favours and obligations, and to enmesh others in future obligation. I am sure that when feelings of genuine generosity and real friendliness exist they would also be expressed by giving.

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In the parts and quantities of meat first distributed or given in the later waves of sharing there seemed to be no taboo and no rigidity of rule.

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The distribution of an eland which was killed by Gao Beard, headman of Band 2, will serve as an example. There were more than a hundred !Kung at Gautscha at the time of the hunt. Both Gautscha bands (Bands 1 and 2) were present. Bands 3, 4, and 7 were visiting and there was a sprinkling of visitors from other bands.

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The hunting party was composed of four men: Gao Beard; his first wife's brother, //Ao, and his own brother, /Qui, both of whom lived with him in Band 2; his brother-in-law, !Naishi, the husband of his sister, //Kushay. They were visiting at the time.

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The party had hunted for eight days without success in heat so exhausting that they had to lie covered with sand through the middle part of the day.

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/Qui was the first to see the eland. It was a huge one. As /Qui had been asked to come on the hunt by his brother to help him, he told Gao Beard where the eland was and did not shoot at it himself.

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Two boys joined the men to track the eland after it was shot. The party tracked it for three days and then found it dead from the poison. They cut up the meat and brought it to the werf at Gautscha, which was two days' travel away. The hunt had lasted thirteen days in all.

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Gao Beard was himself the owner of the arrow. The arrow had been given by one person to another five times. /Gao Music (Band 1), who made it, gave it to his sister, /Goishay, who gave it to her husband, #Gao, headman of Band 3. He gave it to his brother, Gao, also of Band 3, who gave it to his wife, Di!ai. Di!ai gave it to Gao Beard, her brother, who shot the eland with it and who was responsible for the distribution of the meat.

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Gao Beard first gave meat to the hunters who helped him, as was the custom. To !Naishi he gave a forequarter and to //Ao a forequarter and the head. (The hunters usually received a forequarter or hindquarter or an equivalent amount. The head was an extra gift.) The two boys who helped track got nothing—because their fathers would give them some, we were told. To our

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astonishment, /Qui was given nothing. Gao Beard explained that his brother would eat from his pot. (Actually he  240 might eat more in this way as he would not have to share that cooked meat with anyone but his wife and child.)

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